slow examination of the traces of a messy, sub-tropical riverine past by a native situated in an over-kinetic, chaotic, deltaic present.

This same sense of understatement, arrived at after much filtering and distillation, is also to be found in the other group of photographs on display—*Mr and Mrs Das*—where Protick documents the last days of two of his grandparents who spent their lives working for the Baptist Church in East Pakistan/ Bangladesh. Images of the ailing couple are sparsely distributed among images of their flat and medical paraphernalia, and are all the more powerful for not being ubiquitous. A switchboard, a still ceiling fan, a picture of Christ with a 3D crown of small, shiny balloons, the corner of a stairway, a pile of books echoing the pile of rotting volumes in the *Jhirno* series are all somehow imbued with love; unlike the photographs of the ruins and landscape, these are in colour, but only barely so. At first, you are reminded of old, hand-tinted photos, but then you see the chromatic signature that only digital working can produce and, again, you find yourself walking on the liminal *alkhet* (as the raised earth boundaries between fields are called in Bangla) between different segments of time.

Do go and see these photos and the video work by Sarker Protick. Shrine Empire Gallery is to be lauded for presenting such a strong new 'voice', so to speak, from the churn of exciting photography being produced in Bangladesh. In these fraught and divided times, work such as this transcends national borders and happily reminds us of our larger identity as subcontinentals. ■

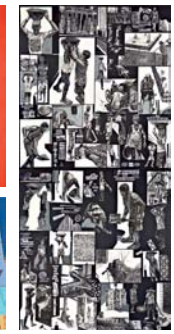
Ruchir Joshi

The Calcutta Connect

New shows by Kolkata's galleries







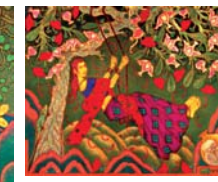
COLOURS OF FREEDOM
Visual Arts Gallery, Habitat Centre, New Delhi
(Until November 10)

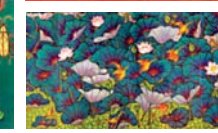
Presented by Kolkata's CIMA Gallery and curated by its director Rakhi Sarkar, this group exhibition asks a crucial question: How has India's visual space been shaped by the 75 years of its freedom? On display are excerpts from Satyajit Ray's *Pather Panchali*, textiles, indigenous subaltern art and works by 50-odd artists—S.H. Raza, M.F. Husain, Manjit Bawa, Lalu Prasad Shaw, Nalini Malani et al.

SONGS OF RECLAMATION
The Art of A. Ramachandran
Emami Art, Kolkata
(Until December 31)

Though West Bengal had a huge influence on A. Ramachandran's early career—he holds a diploma in fine arts and crafts from Santiniketan's Kala Bhavan—the Padma Bhushan-awardee has never seen his work exhibited in Kolkata on a large retrospective scale. Curated by art historian R. Siva Kumar, this solo includes Ramachandran's paintings, sculptures, drawings and illustrations for children's books.







TREES, SHOOTS & LEAVES

Chameli Ramachandran's new exhibition transplants nature to the gallery

ENCHANTED GARDEN
Chameli Ramachandran
Vadehra Art Gallery
(Until November 11)

There is a peculiar pleasure in seeing deftly painted watercolours, or, in this case, renderings of botanical forms in brush and ink. As a senior practitioner of painting, Chameli Ramachandran has had a long and notable career. Here she gives us chamber music of a sort: repetitions and variations of flowers, plants and trees.

The consummate skill in the brush—touch makes almost all the paintings satisfying to look at individually; in isolation, most of them would, of course, look lovely on the wall of a well-appointed hallway or living room.





However, one can't help looking forward to Ramachandran's future presentations where she might choose to be a tad more adventurous in varying the tones and colours of her beautifully observed forms. My favourite work in this exhibition was one of the tree paintings she painted in Rochester, New York, where the deep blacks really make an anarchic dance in the softer tones of the grey trunks. ■

Ruchir Joshi